

This can lead you to a very tempting notion of defining exact dimensions for everything. But this is not always the best way to go about things. You should be aware of the inherent flexibility of the web as a viewing platform, and that there are a multitude of ways a web page is viewed – different screens, different browsers, different devices and different screen resolutions.

Two options for measurement that are available through CSS are absolute and relative. As long as web designers apply a measure of control in their style sheets, relative measurements actually do a much better job of tightening the design while also making it full proof without pitfalls in terms of display.

2.6.1 Absolute measurements

Absolute values are fixed, specific measurements. They let you be exact in your measurements and control the display of your web pages. Absolute values in CSS are inches (in), centimeters (cm), millimeters (mm), points (pt), and picas (pc). Absolute measurements will only give the results based on the fact that the browser interprets the number of pixels on the screen and the dimensions of the screen. Often, these might be wrong. Not all computers know how big the screen is. In these cases, the browser makes a guess and assumes a size. But it is good to note that almost all generic day to day CSS design doesn't require absolute measurements, so let's skip to the implementation of relative measurements.

Note - A point (pt) is 1/72 of an inch and a pica (pc) is equivalent to 12 points, or a sixth of an inch.

2.6.2 Relative measurements

Relative measurements unlike absolute values are calculated in comparison to an inherited value. The relative values in CSS are percentage (%), x-height (ex), ems (em), and pixels (px). Our web sites will primarily be viewed on computer screens, but you can never be sure about the screen resolution or the browser. Some end users might view your site on PDAs, cellphones, projectors, or even on HDTVs. Consider also that many users manually configure their devices to suit their own preferences (like screen resolutions), so it is necessary that your design is not compromised in these situations. A very important thing to maintain in web design is accessibility, ensuring that all your visitors can access all the content you wish to provide.

Relative measurements are proven to provide the best solution for text resizing. While relative values give the designer less control, they do create a better experience for the end user.